

Impact: High Difficulty: Medium Misuse risk: Medium

CORE FORMULA

Cut words in half -> Lead with the point -> Earn elaboration

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Take whatever you were about to say and cut it in half. Lead with the most important word or sentence. Leave the rest.

BEST FOR

- Written communication — email, messages, reports
- Presentations with time constraints
- High-stakes verbal answers where clarity matters most
- Any communication where the reader or listener is busy

PHRASE BANK

Brevity Openers · Signalling you are being concise

- "Short version: ..."
- "In one sentence: ..."
- "The headline is..."
- "Two things: ..."
- "I will keep this brief: ..."
- "The core of it is..."
- "Bottom line: ..."

Cut Phrases · Catching and shortening

- "Actually — let me say that more simply."
- "I am over-explaining. The point is: ..."
- "Shorter version: ..."
- "Let me get to the point faster."
- "I will spare the context and say: ..."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Three paragraphs of context before the ask
Better: Here is the background — I need X.
Best: I need X by Y. Context in one sentence below.
2. Weak: Five-minute verbal explanation of a simple point
Better: I will try to keep this short...
Best: One sentence answer. Pause. Add one piece of context only if needed.
3. Weak: Email with no clear structure: all text, no hierarchy
Better: I have organised this into sections.
Best: Key point in bold at the top. Brief support below. Clear ask at the end.

DECISION TREE

If You are about to write a long email

Ask: can I say this in one paragraph? One sentence? Cut accordingly.

If You are about to give a long verbal answer

State the core in one sentence first. Offer detail after.

"The short answer is X. Happy to give you more context if useful."

If You are mid-sentence and realising it is too long

Stop. Restate in fewer words.

"Actually — let me cut that down. The point is simply: ..."

If You are being brief but losing important information

Add back only the essential context. Not everything that is interesting.

"The one piece of context that changes this is..."

SCENARIOS

Replying to a senior person's question in a meeting

One sentence answer. Then pause. — "Yes — the project is on track for Thursday."

Writing a message to someone with limited time

Lead with the ask. One line of context. Stop. — "I need your sign-off on X. Background below if useful."

Explaining a complex idea to a non-expert

Say the clearest version. Cut the jargon. — "The simplest way to say it is..."

Giving a status update in a meeting

Status first. Risk second. Ask third. Everything else is noise. — "On track. One risk: [name it]. No decisions needed from you right now."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- In relationship-building contexts where brevity reads as cold or dismissive.
- When explaining complex technical topics to non-experts — completeness matters more than brevity.
- In emotional conversations where being concise can feel uncaring.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Word count audit

Take one email you wrote today and cut it by half. Notice what you removed. Was it necessary?

Day 2 — One sentence test

For every question you are asked today, attempt a one-sentence answer before elaborating.

Day 3 — Lead with the point

In three communications today, put the most important sentence first.

Day 4 — Earn the detail

After a brief answer, wait to be asked for more before adding it.

Day 5 — Cut filler

Identify and remove all filler phrases from one communication: 'as I mentioned', 'just to say', 'I wanted to reach out' etc.

Day 6 — Verbal brevity

In one meeting, aim to make your contributions 50% shorter than usual.

Day 7 — Calibration

Was your communication received better? Did brevity ever cost you something important? Where was it most effective?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I cut the communication by at least a third?
- Did I lead with the most important point?
- Did I offer elaboration rather than force it?
- Did I remove all filler phrases?
- Was the brevity appropriate for the context — not cold in a warm situation?
- Did I write in a way that respects the reader's time?
- Did the communication land more clearly as a result?